help? No one forced you to come."

What he said was true, but also not true. She tried to hold these thoughts together, recalling the French soldier who'd spat in her coffee. He motioned to the pew, signaling her to sit. She stepped back and slid onto the wooden seat.

"Who are you mourning?" he asked.

"My mother." It was only half a lie. She hadn't come here to mourn anyone, but if she had, it would be Maman. He touched her arm in sympathy, and it took all Rose's strength not to flinch. His blue eyes locked on hers.

"Your mother died?" He tilted his head, and thick blond hair fell across his forehead.

Léa's warning not to tell anyone they were orphans came to her, but that was back in Orléans, under the harsh conditions of the Occupation. Rose couldn't see why it mattered here. "Both my parents are gone, my mother more recently."

"Then we share that in common. I, too, am an orphan, and until this morning . . ." He held back a sob. "It was only my brother Felix and me."

She relaxed slightly, knowing he had a sibling. She noticed the crease on his bottom lip. "What happened to your brother?"

"A letter came this morning. Felix died fighting in Stalingrad." His crystal blue eyes darted around the church, almost childlike in their confusion. "I sensed something was wrong when my letters came back unopened." His shoulders heaved; tears fell on his perfectly pressed uniform.

"My condolences," she said, trying to reconcile the man in the uniform with the innocent boy he must have once been, the one who had looked up at his mother with the same blue eyes full of love as Rose had looked at her mother.

"Should we light our candles?" she asked.

He nodded, removing a white handkerchief from his pocket to wipe his eyes. "Please forgive me, I shouldn't—"

He removed a brass lighter from his jacket pocket, flicked the top open and lit her candle. The swastika set in a red and white diamond in the center of the lighter called out like a warning, but she wanted to think of him as the eighteen-year-old he must have been when the war broke out. How